would make things increasingly difficult for India and force them to the negotiating table. Second, that by directing the 'spearhead' against the BJP, they could use domestic opposition to the nuclear tests to weaken the Indian leadership's hand. Having pushed their 'asks' through a collective decision of the UN Security Council in June 1998, and established their *locus standi* in South Asia via the Clinton–Jiang Zemin Joint Statement of 27 June 1998, the Chinese presumed that the Indians would likely buckle to the demands, and the US would stand firm.

It was on these presumptions that they crafted their policy of building pressure on India. The policy was one of deliberate 'cooling and isolation' in terms of contacts. China insisted that they were the aggrieved party and had been slandered by India. They used the Chinese proverb 'whoever has tied the knot on the tiger's neck must untie it' (*jie ling xi ling*), to suggest that it was for India to make unilateral reparations by, metaphorically, untying the knot they had tied. This was the Chinese way of laying down pre-conditions for India to fulfil before the restoration of normality in the bilateral relationship. As if on cue, the legion of Chinese 'academics' came out to justify the 'party line', including veteran India-watchers Ye Zhengjia and Wang Hongwei, both scholars of 1960s vintage, who harped on the Indian perfidy in dragging China's name into the matter and thus creating a new obstacle for the development of India–China relations. Given the paucity of direct access in China to decision-makers by foreign diplomats, most embassies carefully parsed academic writings from key Chinese think tanks affiliated to the Party and the government. The Chinese, therefore, knew that Indians would get the message that China expected them to kowtow, and to make amends for falsely accusing the Chinese of being a 'threat', if the bilateral relationship was to return to the normal track.